

Name is a Required Field: Politics of Deadnaming in Administrative Systems

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Abstract

Deadnaming is the act of referring to a transgender person by a name they no longer identify with. When carried out by administrative technologies, deadnaming can be a strategy of control which demands legible and singular identification. Interfaces that introduce ‘lived name’ fields are insufficient at best and violent at worst, as demonstrated by a close read of the University of California Gender Recognition and Lived Name Policy; under the guise of a solution, they produce arbitrary binaries and force trans people to fulfill the impossible task of making themselves readable to an opaque system. By embracing the mutability of names, trans people reveal points of breakdown which allow HCI researchers to envision alternative technologies focused on glitching, evasion, and multiplicity rather than surveillance and presumed accuracy.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics** → **Gender; Surveillance; Management of computing and information systems**; • **Human-centered computing** → *HCI theory, concepts and models*.

Keywords

transgender, gender identity, names, deadnaming, misgendering, surveillance, administrative systems

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1 INTRODUCTION

Trigger warning: this work discusses deadnaming, transphobia, gender dysphoria, and violence against trans people. Please read with care.

Like every other teenager, I decided college was going to be a fresh start for me. I packed my bags, moved across the country, and nervously decided to start going by Ace. It felt strange on my tongue and in my fingers when I typed it, but it was every bit as exciting. Across the seemingly endless online portals I accessed

in the months leading up to orientation, everything seemed to indicate that my birth name wouldn’t show up except for where it was necessary, which I could only guess meant financial and legal documents. For the first time in my life, nobody needed to know I was transgender. Nobody needed to know my birth name. I would be in control. When I picked up my freshman orientation nametag, I saw my birth name, with ‘Ace’ written beside it in quotes like a nickname. My heart dropped. I covered my birth name with a sticker and hoped nobody would ask.

Transgender (trans) people are, by virtue of circumstance, practitioners of what cárdenas calls shifting, “a gesture of modulating one’s perceptibility by changing one’s form, location, or appearance” [10]. One common practice of shifting is choosing new names, which we-as-trans-people¹ do for a variety of reasons: to reduce misgendering, to create distance from a former self, to carve out a new identity in our shape. In doing so, however, we raise a ghost – our deadname. Through this work, I opt for the term ‘deadname’ to refer to a name assigned at birth that a trans person no longer identifies with, not just for its necrotic connotations but also to signal its potential for real violence and gender dysphoria.² I also write it as a single word rather than as ‘dead name’ to emphasize that it is not simply a type of name, but rather a new entity which takes on its own meaning, inside our data and outside our bodies.

After deciding on a new name, trans people spend our lives followed by our ghosts. We make tacit agreements to ignore each other’s PayPal information. I promise never to Google my friends. Researchers share reminders to cite one another correctly [5, 43]. Beyond the everyday violence³ of being deadnamed by other people, we are also haunted by information systems where “outdated data stick, maintaining a connection between a past and present identity and drawing a trans history into focus” [34]. Records of our names proliferate across uncountable databases, often without our knowledge or consent, as we are forced to continuously disclose ourselves to black boxes. One such haunted ground is particularly close to home: the ACM Digital Library (DL), where you have likely accessed this work.

Academic publishers endeavor to make work available and useful to other researchers, to ensure that authors receive proper credit, and to keep a historical record of research communities. Names, however, are not the static identifiers which they are often assumed

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¹I borrow the term ‘we-as-trans-people’ from Os Keyes to highlight the autoethnographic nature of this paper, throughout which I slip in and out of first person.

²Gender dysphoria can be described as “the emotional distress associated with an individual’s experience with their gendered body or social experiences” [38].

³Throughout this paper, the term “violence” encompasses both physical and non-physical harm, particularly as these non-physical or less immediately clear forms of violence can be used to justify later physical violence.

to be. What, then, are trans researchers left to do if they choose to change their name, particularly after they have published work? To address this reality, trans researchers formed the Name Change Policy Working Group (NCPWG) [44] to develop a name change policy for the ACM. In the face of significant pushback, the NCPWG was able to successfully advocate for their work, and the policy has been in effect since 2019. It provides authors with three options [1]:

- (1) Separate identities, where old and new names are unlinked.
- (2) Linked identities, where searches for either old or new names will return results for both.
- (3) Updated identity, where the old name is replaced with the new name in prior publications. This includes corrected versions of past publications and updated metadata within the ACM DL. Citing works can also be updated with author consent.

Following the enactment of this policy, the NCPWG published an essay detailing its vetting process, which included anonymous feedback from any ACM members. In this work, they share common objections to the proposed policy, revealing transphobic perspectives of the ACM community when respondents repeatedly claim that allowing name changes will mean that anyone can “revise history” or “use this policy for fraudulent ends.” In their rebuttals, the NCPWG make clear the goal of the policy: “making certain that the entire bibliography of an author is attributed using the same name” [44]. We must place higher value on supporting trans scholars experiencing real harm than hypothetical bad actors, particularly when already operating within the good-faith system of academic publishing. Too often, trans people are assumed to be deceitful when trying to move towards a more accurate, more real, more just form of identification. An accommodating name change policy isn’t concerned with falsifying the historical record, it’s about correcting towards accurate authorship.

Institutional change is slow, but it would grind to a halt without the work of researchers like the NCPWG working to make HCI a more equitable space for trans and queer community research. Originating at a CSCW 2018 “lunchshop”, Scheuerman et al. have developed a living document of HCI guidelines for gender inclusivity [39]. (Notably, Haimson detailed the surprising lack of gender inclusion at that same conference [20].) Ahmed’s proposal of “trans-competent interaction design” offers a starting point to trans-inclusive practice [4], and Spiel et al. offer direction for improving the fluidity of the ever-present gender field in surveys [42]. Growing scholarship from trans researchers like DeVito et al. [14] means that work like mine can be supported. In this work, I write directly to two of my communities. First, I speak to *trans people*, both those who I reference and those who might come after me, to illustrate the realities and futures of our technology use. Second, and perhaps more urgently, I speak to the *CHI community*. I urge us as HCI researchers to question the necessity of collecting names as static data, to move towards technology that is not only trans-inclusive but trans-imaginative.

1.1 METHODS AND POSITIONALITY

This work uses autoethnography as a method to share concrete, evocative descriptions and reflections of the first author’s experiences as a transgender man in the United States [15, 37]. We build

upon a growing practice of autoethnography in HCI [29] as a way to make visible the tensions that marginalized communities encounter when interacting with technology [22, 25, 26, 47]. All instances of first person language, including those in the introduction, are from the point of view of the first author. Contextually, the use of “we” throughout this paper may refer to a broad transgender community, rather than the two authors of the work. The first author of this work is transmasculine, Chinese, and primarily English-speaking. The second author is white, primarily English-speaking, and identifies as a disabled queer woman.

2 OUR NAMES ARE ALIVE

A name is the most basic form of encoding. Although one’s birth name is almost never self-selected, most people carry it with them until, and often past, death. It is a variable, a piece of text assigned to a piece of memory. However, unlike most variables, they are often non-unique. Knowing multiple people with the same name reveals how identification always depends on context [30]. Saying someone’s first name is enough to bring to mind impressions of an entire person, but it is not always the right one; in conversation, you use contextual information like relationship networks, location, and subject matter to correctly identify the person to whom that name refers. This context navigation is also what allows names to be inherently fluid. We collect nicknames, handles, endearments, insults. We adopt them for as little as a conversation or as long as a lifetime. We allow different people access to different variables for ourselves, with one name we might consider ‘global’.

Despite the organic mutability of names in our everyday lives, changing one’s name becomes an unthinkable ordeal when they happen to be trans. Many people choose to legally or socially modify their name: survivors of abuse, people who marry, and immigrants adopting Anglicized names, for example. However, when a trans person does it, the change becomes “illegible and suspect”, even if they have all of their paperwork in order [34]. What sets them apart is not the act or duration of change (a marriage name change in California is just three easy steps⁴) but rather the simple fact of their gender. While Western society widely accepts names as contextual, Keyes points out that it sees gender as objective. Any perceived change in gender, indicated through a change in name, instantly marks and outs a person as trans and therefore incomprehensible. “Misgendering and deadnaming sweep context aside, denying you the possibility of different selves at different places in different points in time” [30]. Because they attempt to alter a fixed trait, trans people are denied the name mutability afforded to cisgender (cis) people.

Being outed can place trans people in extraordinarily dangerous situations, exacerbated if they are also a person of color, disabled, poor, or unhoused.⁵ In these moments, the safest course of action is often to pass as cis, a task which is impossible to measure as a success or failure until after the situation has passed because it necessarily depends on the perspective of the viewer. They must shift

⁴“Three easy steps” is a catchy turn of phrase, but it is also a reference to the California Courts Self-Help Guide.

⁵To make this ‘danger’ more concrete, I often point to the Human Rights Committee’s annual tracking of fatal violence against transgender and gender-expansive people. There were at least 32 recorded instances in 2024 alone, 18 of whom were Black trans women [2].

without anybody noticing – hide their appearance, modulate their voice, control their expressions – because “when they are read as trans instead of cisgender, they are subjected to extreme, incomprehensible violence” [10]. To ensure safety, trans people necessarily shift between identifiers, opting to use their name, deadname, or other variable depending on the circumstance. It is for this reason that I choose to simply say ‘name’ rather than ‘lived’, ‘chosen’, or ‘preferred’ name – it is one of many that we live by and choose, and it is not optional. For trans people, names are a variable to which we carefully and consciously assign value.

3 DIGITAL DEADNAMING

In a digital world, trans people are asked to identify themselves not just to other people, but also to interfaces, systems, datasets. It is not enough for me to go to the university pharmacy to pick up testosterone and wait for them to call my deadname. I must now also log into my health portal with my deadname, send a refill message from my deadname, wait for a response sent to my deadname, receive an invoice addressed to my deadname, and pay for it with an account under my deadname. I must leave behind a miles-long digital trail that actively induces gender dysphoria just to get the thing that alleviates it.

The many trans people like myself who haven’t completed legal name changes find ourselves “being forced to disclose information (like [our] deadnames) through bureaucratic or administrative practices that do not account for or permit the use of chosen names that are not yet legally recognized” [24]. Systems that require or strongly pressure trans people into using their deadnames are described by Wittkower as dysaffordances, which “actively forc[e] non-normative-conforming users to misidentify themselves” just to use them [46]. When trans people constantly encounter systems with dysaffordances, they have no choice but to misgender themselves or disclose their status as trans. The former directly leads to negative affect [35]; the latter can be deeply endangering.

This act of forced continuous disclosure perpetuates what Spade terms *administrative violence*, where administrative systems portrayed as neutral or even protective, like universities, healthcare, and financial services, work to produce, implement, and structure society around prejudice and harm [41]. Nearly all systems demand that we associate ourselves with a singular name, producing a cis-focused lens of fixity. Over repeated offenses, they create a Deleuzian society of control, wherein “one is never finished with anything” [13]. Trans people have no choice but to bend themselves into a legible shape upon signing in to every new slightly different interface, or else they lose access to resources, support, and opportunities. Beyond the initial moment of misidentification and gender dysphoria, however, the lasting violence lies in the structures that administrative systems uphold. Once established, they “invent and produce meaning for the categories they administer” and unevenly endanger certain populations [41]. They produce living norms that can go unquestioned indefinitely. In a case study of how newly-introduced computer systems impacted trans Britons’ government identification, Hicks [23] writes:

Paradoxically, the expansion of the computers’ use, with all the flexibility their programming could have

allowed, instead *reified binary gender* and strengthened the fiction of gender as an unchanged and unchanging category. Despite the enhanced flexibility offered by computerized methods, the digitization of people’s accounts actually resulted in *less flexibility and less accommodating policies for trans people*. (emphasis added)

The problem with computers is the codification of categories that do not permit mutability. Gender, at least in Western society, is a way for authorities to encode people, to mark them, to categorize them. The inevitable development of automatic gender recognition expands its breadth of control when facial analysis services “propagate a reductionist view of gender” that moves steadily downstream into third-party software, to be used in countless applications [38]. The binary logic of computers comes from “a cultural logic that gender is fixed and obvious and therefore an easy classification tool for verifying identity” [41]. The key difference is that computers abstract away the logic. Those in control can hide their inconsistencies and arbitrary decisions behind Galloway’s black box, where “only the inputs and outputs are known” [17]. In fact, trans Britons were informed that no action was required because “the new system did not ‘see’ gender”, when in reality, their records “explicitly positioned them as aberrant” [23]. In this extreme case where they could not see input nor output, trans people were unknowingly and unwillingly encoded as trans, suspect, and illegible.

4 HAUNTED MACHINES

Even in today’s more technically literate world, administrative systems obscure their inner workings – sometimes for reasons of malicious surveillance like Hicks’ study [23], but also due to bureaucratic inconsistencies. When a database relies on an arbitrarily manufactured category like gender, agencies struggle to find reliable methods of classification. A cursory look at the US “reveals the inconsistency of laws and policies in this area between different states and even between different agencies within any given state” [41]. Nobody can agree on a best practice for an impossible task; uneven implementation of rules might mean that at a different office in a different city, one might be able to more easily change their gender marker by “sneak[ing] in under the old policy” [3]. These deviations in the black boxes of administrativia can be exploited for trans people’s benefit (as will be explored in later sections), but they also create insurmountable barriers. Being illegible to classification has dire consequences, as trans people with intersecting identities become simultaneously harder to support and easier to punish or incarcerate. With this in mind, we return to the careful selection of name and gender in a way that minimizes harm. A deadname can be better than physical violence; a closet can be preferable to a coffin.

Often, trans people adopt a mix of names across platforms: some demand real names while others are sites for experimentation. In his work on social media as social transition machinery, Haimson describes how “identity change requires network separation” as he surveys trans people with different identities across platforms [19]. However, as our mismatched data proliferates across these systems over time, we start to feel haunted by the multiplicity of our identities. When I do decide to pursue a legal name change, I will have

to contend with decades worth of my deadname on the internet in databases that I have no way of scrubbing. Mackenzie [34] describes this growing volume of data as, citing Ceglowski, like toxic waste: “it is dangerous long after it has been created and forgotten”. Not only do we need to contend with what we produce today, we must also confront a long history of misidentification. Systems cannot accept that one person can take many shapes, revealing a “queer temporality” when our former names and aliases reach towards us from the past [34]. Despite every effort that trans people may take to compartmentalize identities and avoid self-deadnaming except where absolutely necessary, our deadnames take on a life of their own within the records of our past. Because this data clings to us, often against our will, they enable our administrative systems “to functionally mark and out those people as trans; to collapse the distance between contexts in which one is out or not” [30]. Unexpected context collapse can unwillingly out a trans person, again exposing them to violence. For most trans people, complete stealth is not an option – unless you somehow play your cards perfectly or find every server and smash it, “the identification data created about trans people do not disappear when individuals change their name” [34]. We remain haunted because we are forced to be legible.

5 CASE STUDY: UC GRLN POLICY

What is a solution to an impossible task? If institutions can find arbitrary ways to miscategorize people, there must be an equally arbitrary way to ‘accurately’ identify oneself. Given the increasing literacy around trans issues, systems have begun introducing additional features to accommodate for multiple names and non-binary genders. One such example is the University of California (UC) Gender Recognition and Lived Name (GRLN) Policy, introduced in 2020. As suggested by its title, the policy outlines steps that every UC and associated unit must have taken by the end of 2023 to reflect the “accurate gender identity and lived name” of all affiliated persons [12]. At UC Berkeley, where I began this work, much of it has already been applied across administrative portals like bCourses, the campus’ learning management system, and CalCentral, a resource hub for students to navigate enrollment, academic progress, and finances. This case study will draw from both the policy text and my own experience of its implementation.

5.1 DEFINING TERMS

The policy begins with a list of definitions for different sexualities and gender identities. This includes a definition for ‘dead name’, which notes that the phrasing “is intended to stress the inappropriateness” of misgendering someone; however, it chooses to use the term ‘legal name’ in lieu of ‘dead name’, presumably because the policy is aimed towards cases where someone has not gone through a legal name change [12]. Why, one must wonder, does it choose to define ‘dead name’ in all its severity without committing to saying it? Perhaps to gesture towards sensitivity about the issue, to prove that it is in touch with the terminology that trans people may use for ourselves. Contrarily, it chooses to use the term ‘lived name’ which, as discussed previously, is a misnomer, especially within a system that still forces one to live as their legal name under certain (often unclear) circumstances. It is marginally better than ‘preferred

name’,⁶ but the policy treats them synonymously. The decision to use the words ‘legal’ and ‘lived’ is of particular interest because it establishes a binary between the two. The multiplicity of our names is subject to “dimensional subtractivism”, where there is no room for contextualization [17]. If you are trans, your legal and lived names must certainly be different. Paradoxically, ‘lived name’ is the optional field of the two, reserved for trans people who would like to indicate “a lived name *in addition* to their legal name” (emphasis added) [12], as if living is optional but law is mandatory. By providing a lived name, trans people mark themselves as trans to the UC system, a massive network wrapped in a staggering amount of red tape.

To that end, the policy is framed as specifically helping trans individuals navigate the institution’s labyrinthine information systems. Mixed into these interpretations of queer terms are the definitions for ‘information technology (IT) resources’, ‘primary IT resource’, and ‘downstream IT resource’. From the start, this policy makes it clear that it was not written for non-discrimination in person-to-person interactions – it is to make clear the datafication of trans users, to inform us of how computers will digest our names. Not to make it easier or safer to be trans at a UC, but to make it easier for the UC to know we are trans. Beauchamp asserts that trans people are ‘inextricable from the surveillance and security measures that work to produce and regulate them’ [7]. Our existence is conditional on our willingness to give up privacy in favor of legibility. We are deemed trans because the system strips us down to our data. We give into the illusion of digital confidentiality by submitting information which ultimately outs us.

5.2 UC’S BLACK BOX

Despite definitions of IT and the promise of “a clear and efficient process” [12], the systems are still ultimately unpredictable black boxes. Following Spade’s assessment of US legal policy, the UC system is rife with inconsistencies. In my personal experience, I have seen my deadname routinely show up where it is not necessary: name badges, waitlist and enrollment emails, alumni communications, transcript requests, library renewals, and more. During a summer academic session, my deadname was printed on a spreadsheet of room availabilities, exposing it not just to my course staff but to all summer instructors. The policy tells me to cede my deadname to primary IT resources (CalCentral, UCPath, eTang, and CalNet), which I am supposed to trust to make decisions on my behalf about whether or not to send my data downstream. I have done as it asks and yet I am regularly, carelessly misgendered. Lack of clarity about where gender data propagates means that it has the “potential to cascade into endless domains” [38]. In Keyes’ words, this process of data inheritance “does not acknowledge the flexibility and mutability of gender in different contexts” [30]. I cannot tell the system that I want to use a certain name in a certain place because it decides for me. There is no option for me to simply withhold my deadname from information systems that do not need it.

However, even if I did have this option, I would have no way of being certain that my deadname is required by a particular service.

⁶The term preferred name implies that calling someone by their name is simply a matter of preference rather than one of respect.

Neither the GRLN policy nor UC Berkeley’s informational site ⁷ have exhaustive lists on which services need my deadname. The GRLN policy has a list disclaiming that it “is not limited to the following” [12], and Berkeley’s site unhelpfully offers that there are systems that *might* need your deadname. They share steps of how to add my name, but there is a palpable disconnect between the front and back end of these systems. As Mackenzie observes through forums of trans people managing their credit reports, “the most common experience... was confusion and inconsistency” [34]. Trans people are left in the dark and expected to approve of a policy that simply asks us to datafy ourselves. Even though there are nice, clear instructions on how to update my lived name as an input, I continue to have no real control over where my deadname appears.

5.3 IMPOSSIBLE CATEGORIES

Adding a few extra input fields is not a real solution, and it is a band-aid fix at best. The GRLN policy echoes Facebook’s 2014 decision to introduce 56 new gender options which all ultimately resolve into ‘he’, ‘she’, and ‘them’ [9]. Despite what appears to be a major corporation acknowledging the fiction of binary gender, Gaboury asserts that the act of identification reveals how “the impetus behind Facebook’s move remained deeply tied to a kind of binary logic, or at the very least a digital one” [16]. It does not permit the mutability of trans identity. Instead, it harks back to Deleuze: “the man of control is undulatory, in orbit, in a continuous network” [13]. Even if we are allowed to change ourselves, the UC system can also continuously adapt, creating new rules to fine-tune its mechanisms of control. We are presented with the GRLN policy as something to laud, a step in the right direction. “We are taught that corporations have a soul, which is the most terrifying news in the world” [13]. I ask that we resist reading this policy as progressive, and that we refuse to congratulate the UC system for doing something that marks us as trans.

Even as it gestures towards inclusivity, the policy exposes the arbitrariness of its gendering system within the text. One of the innumerable databases to which our information is sent is the federal government’s Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS). Even though the UC has introduced a minimum of three options (‘man’, ‘woman’, and ‘nonbinary’) on all forms, it is still required to report binary genders (‘male’ and ‘female’) to IPEDS. Its solution is as follows, interpreted by me as a code snippet⁸ to highlight its calculative nature:

```
if (student.isMale || student.isTransMan)
  IPEDS.genderMarker = Male
else if (student.isFemale || student.isTransWoman)
  IPEDS.genderMarker = Female
else
  var lastDigitID = student.ID % 10
  if (lastDigitID % 2 == 0)
    IPEDS.genderMarker = Female
  else if (lastDigitID % 2 == 1)
    IPEDS.genderMarker = Male
```

⁷Each UC has its own campus-specific implementation of the policy, and Berkeley has a page about how to manage your data.

⁸The code snippet I write is inspired by micha cárdenas’ use of code poetry in *Poetic Operations* [10].

The official UC policy for those who lie outside the male/female binary or simply decline to state is to randomly assign their gender marker based on the last digit of their student/employee ID. If someone chooses to make themselves less readable in a binary system, the UC will take a literal number and extract a gender from it anyway. I struggle to overstate how ridiculous this policy is. Perhaps this example, more than anything, proves how proposed solutions of ‘gender recognition’ are, in actuality, strategies to encode and control trans people. *If you don’t tell us your gender, we’ll make one up for you.* Solutions like the UC GRLN are unsatisfactory at best and harmful at worst because they obscure how our self-identification data is used to bind us to binaries of legal/lived, male/female, trans/not trans – binaries that we-as-trans-people reveal to be arbitrary when the systems themselves betray their own logics.

6 ENVISIONING ALTERNATIVES

Systems that force us to identify ourselves are not liberatory; “more information generates more risk” [6]. What, then, might an alternative look like? Throughout this section, I frame my recommendations primarily to two communities I am part of: (1) trans users, to imagine modes of resistance against oppressive systems, and (2) HCI researchers, perhaps more importantly, to imagine paths towards alternative technologies. In doing so, I echo Anonymous et al. in their call to community members to reclaim their own narratives and their call to action demanding that you acknowledge disabled scholars as your peers [48]. If you are a cisgender HCI researcher, I want it to be clear that I am speaking to you through both of framings, as this paper is making visible the knowledge that trans people already possess.

The alternatives I present offer directions for design, though it is critical that we do not adopt a techno-solutionist lens to move forward. Much like how end-of-life scholarship identifies death as a point of system breakdown and transformation [32], trans existence in binary systems reveals opportunities for glitch which solution-oriented thinking fails to anticipate. Rather than coming away from this work with a list of problems to solve, I encourage you to start from joy, where the goal is not to fix but to flourish [45].

To envision systems beyond deadnaming, I propose three possible directions – not solutions, but perspectives from which we might design something new. First, we might exploit inconsistencies and errors, human and machine alike, to become un-markable. Second, citing Galloway [17], we might seek ‘the whatever’ by becoming invisible, anonymous. Finally, and most importantly, we return to the multiplicity of our names to find solace in the shift and build a world that embraces the mutable self. Underscoring these speculations, I highlight Spade’s reminder that our object is “improving life chances for trans people and making sure that our work does not build up the criminal punishment systems”, and that we must come from “a place of shared struggle and collective analysis” rather than symbolic goals of visibility and accuracy [41]. It is not a success to make ourselves more identifiable to systems that do not care about us, or to punish those who do not meet our criteria. If we uphold carceral structure, we are no better than our oppressors.

6.1 EXPLOIT ERROR

“Just like sex, data are socially constructed” [34]. Rather than misgendering and deadnaming ourselves – offering up unpleasant information in the name of ‘accuracy’ – we-as-trans-people can take advantage of the human tendency to make mistakes. In Mackenzie’s research of trans forums, they find cis-passing trans people who “successfully convinced data entry clerks that the ‘M’ or ‘F’ on their IDs were erroneously entered” [34]. Under the guise of clerical error, they are able to bypass the financial and administrative barriers of legally changing their sex markers. Calling back to *cárdenas*’ perspective on passing, a clerk becomes accomplice when they “make a decision about whether or not a person fits into a particular category” [10]. Cis-passing trans people are afforded invisibility, the ability to temporarily overwrite their trans existence with a shift deemed successful by popular opinion. As a result, it can be easier to blame human subjectivity than to conform to institutional rigidity. These strategies of evasion can work even if one has data ghosts following them. Other forum writers in Mackenzie’s work were able to add themselves as authorized users on credit card accounts under their deadnames, or claim a deadname was a relative or typo that a former customer service representative made [34]. Omission of sensitive information is a way to avoid further violence and harm by unquestionably slotting into a system.

However, stealth is not a reliable strategy for many if not most trans people. Instead, we might search for loopholes. In her history of Facebook’s gender encoding, Bivens describes how users developed a method of hacking their gender by exploiting the software’s legacy inclusion of an unidentified gender marker [9]. By inspecting the site and editing its HTML, users could manually set their gender from 1 (female) or 2 (male) to 0 (undefined). Leveraging exploits and unpatched errors offers opportunities for a glitchy existence. Far from prioritizing passing, we move towards the illegible.

Systems are hard to change, and their harm ripples out far beyond the boundaries of ‘intent’. A harmless and well-made sign-up form becomes permanently codified data that takes a life of its own. But what if that form was not so well-made? What if we tried to build leaky systems? Would it be so harmful to leave room for loopholes, to leave weak points for breakdown, to let errors be errors? Your answers to these questions might vary depending on what you intend to build. However, I urge us as HCI researchers to reconsider when and why names, gender, and other identifying information might be considered required. If a user’s name is not mission-critical data, perhaps it is best to leave it untouched. To build a leaky system leaves it open to a poetics of glitch, when users can “perform a movement across identities” and “offer an interruption to normative flows” [11]. Perhaps by embracing these interruptions, we can create less harmful technologies.

6.2 BECOME NOTHING

Where one form of evasion might rely on passing, another is to become invisible. Instead of working to make ourselves legible to systems that capture us, we might look for ways to be unreadable. Galloway posits that in the present moment, “a practical nonexistence can emerge from a being that is practically nonexistent, that subtracting being ($n - 1$) might be the only thing today that capitalism cannot eventually co-opt” [17]. Putting this theory into

practice in our current systems might lead to confusing results; if I were to opt out of identifying a gender in CalCentral, it would pick one for me anyways. However, it moves us away from the virtue signaling of empty visibility without protection for bodies that are already hypervisible. Capitalism promises us a false utopia of productivity and innovation “that queer failure looks to refuse, offering up ways of living otherwise” [16]. To embrace failure – of legibility, of recognition – can let us resist identification from systems that would no longer know how to harm us. Outside our institutions, anonymity thrives in activism and organizing, where safety means avoiding capture: turn off location, wear black bloc, cover your face. However, radical demands are not a prerequisite for mastering invisibility when anonymity thrives in even the most mundane of online spaces. “The new mantra is: *we have no demands...* We want to leave be, *to leave being*” [17]. To be unreadable to a system that preys on trans people, you might create an online persona that is untraceable. Drawing on Muñoz’s strategies of disidentification [36], in the midst of neoliberal systems that demand individuality, you might try to become nothing.

Anonymity is a privilege afforded to those who fit; to misfit is to be visible in an “incongruent relationship” [18]. When people describe trans visibility as a form of advocacy, they fail to recognize them as misfits who are too often hypervisible to systems of violence. How might we allow trans users to become invisible? How might technology demand less of its users? How do we make data not simply mutable but altogether destructible? Collecting ‘accurate identification’ is already a flawed endeavor, as we have seen when infrastructural systems so often fail to read non-binary input correctly [9, 38]. Resisting the urge to adhere to these false categorizations means building technology which accepts and allows one incomplete portrayal instead of comprehensive identification. In fact, Haimson has shown that encouraging semi-anonymous profiles rather than enforcing real-name policies turns social media into a site of positive transformation across networks [19]. Suitable identification is a social action which changes depending on audience. In many cases, qualities can be skipped altogether, as Bennett describes how many visual aspects of appearance are only circumstantially included in image descriptions based on who might access them [8]. To allow users to become nothing, then, is to simply give them the choice. As real-name policies continue to proliferate, internet anonymity becomes a strategy to regain control [28]. To allow users to become nothing, to become anonymous, to shift into invisibility, is to return agency to them.

6.3 BECOME EVERYTHING

But invisibility does not always work. Gaboury warns us that it is “an unequally distributed privilege accessible principally to those normative bodies who are already least visible to power” [17]. As per Spade’s reminder, we must think towards an alternative that all trans people may access, not one that is afforded only to people with the means to pass or conceal themselves. To do so, let us return to where we started. Let us remember what it means to be trans. Daniel M. Lavery [33] writes, quoting his friend Julian K. Jarboe,

God blessed me by making me transsexual for the same reason God made wheat but not bread and fruit

but not wine, so that humanity might share in the act of creation.

To be trans is to create: new selves, new names, new lives. By challenging the idea of binary gender, trans people inherently “expose the limits of... rigid and reductive categories in the face of fluid or shifting identities” [24]. Throughout transition, we exist in the world and on the internet under a variety of names depending on context, resisting singular identification. We defy by shifting, proving that “one’s body, like the digital image, can be a sign with more than one signifier” [10]. While this is often a source of danger, it is only so because systems deem us dangerous. At its core, being trans is a miracle. We are capable of holding multiple selves within one person. Rather than forcing context collapse, Keyes suggests that researchers “seek to highlight points of tension: places where aspects of identity reshape, sometimes in unexpected ways, one’s experience of emotional work” [31]. When we consider an alternative to systems that constrict us, why not imagine one where we can become everything we ever have been and will be? Instead of defining new categories, why not forfeit classification entirely? What would it look like for us to create a world that defaults to multiplicity, a life in the shape of trans existence?

I believe this world is possible, and to create it, we must start with the knowledge that mutability is an absolute necessity. It is something stronger than a recommendation. This might be best evidenced by examining the opposite: in their study of automatic gender recognition software, Hamidi et al. identify the harm and negative affect of gender reductionism [21]. When technology misgenders us, it becomes a vector for oppression and surveillance. In contrast, trans users are (and have always been) practitioners of multiplicity. Scheuerman et al. see it in the Instagram users who stump facial analysis algorithms through gender ambiguity [38]. Symms et al. see it in trans youth of color practicing disidentification for “prismatic possibilities” in campus life [40]. Janicki et al. see it in their methods of queering technologies of productivity [27]. Trans life is a life of movement between different selves; we must allow complexity and messiness into our technologies if we want any shot at allowing people to ‘be themselves’, whatever shape this comes in.

Mutability, of course, is where the ACM name change policy begins and ends. The objections to this policy came from a place of resisting change, a belief that a record can only be reliable and true if it stays the same [44]. For trans people, however, the truth requires change, movement, transformation. Consider the definitions of the prefix *trans*: across, beyond, through. To deny trans people mutability is denial of their identity. How can we be in the business of research, of seeking knowledge, if we cannot accept this fundamental reality? How can we be HCI researchers if we believe our systems will fall when we correct them?

7 CONCLUSION

As they stand, administrative systems like the UC use black boxed interfaces of dysaffordance that force trans people to misidentify ourselves. Continuous forced disclosure gives these authorities a vector of violence and control by marking us as trans in the name of accuracy. However, we embody resistance in our inherent mutability, revealing opportunities to build new futures that not

only permit transness but encourage a world where people are more than a single name. I urge us as HCI researchers to accept loopholes and build hackable systems, to question when users truly need to identify themselves, and to center mutability when building systems. Trans people face impossible situations on a regular basis, often with limited options. While describing Mattie Brice’s *Mainichi*, cárdenas aptly writes, “The player cannot choose, for example, to not be transgender” [10]. In a world that rarely has our best interests at heart, though, we can choose what is best for us, which often takes the form of people who understand and embrace our fluidity of self. We can choose more than just our names. Despite all odds, we can and do choose, every day, to live.

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